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Race, Racism and Administrative Callousness: Using Critical Race Theory for a Race-Conscious Public Administration

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Abstract: This special symposium examines CRT across public and nonprofit spaces to better understand the effects of denying race and racism within the spaces they govern. Although ever present across public administration and nonprofit institutions, explicit discussions and/or initiatives designed to address racism, at the root level, are rare. While an increasingly growing area of interest, the study of public administration continues to avoid explicit conversations capable of leading to institutional shifts in racial justice. The articles included within this symposium move the study of racism (as a system of oppression) by using critical race theory (as a tool to eradicate this unjust system) within the field forward. Each manuscript offers critical race theory as a tool for public administration to move beyond its traditional notions of neutrality, objectivity, and technical rationality into a discipline and practice that accurately contextualizes history, centers the lived experience, and values racial justice as worthy of prioritization and action.

KEYWORDS: Critical race theory; racial justice; social equity

For decades critical scholars have revealed the collaborative and cooperative ways systems of oppression (e.g., racism, sexism, transphobia, classism, ableism) compound disadvantage on underserved communities. However, the release of the *1619 Project* by Nikole Hannah-Jones sparked immediate controversy as she and her colleagues ushered in a counter-narrative about the founding of the United States of America that set factions of the population a blaze. Using anecdotal and archival data, the *1619 Project* makes explicit connections from historical practices to contemporary problems. From the Middle Passage to Hurricane Katrina, authors make explicit connections between brutality, capitalism, and race.

2020 was an anomaly. It had been 100 years since the world experienced a pandemic, while simultaneously confronting a racial reckoning with state-sanctioned violence directed toward Black Americans. The dueling pandemics, as Susan Gooden notes (2020), COVID-19 and racism, brought to the forefront of U.S. consciousness how race and racism has diminished the quality of life for Black, Latino, and Indigenous communities. In communities of color, these realities were not new, but for many people around the globe, this emergent

racial consciousness paved the path for calls of systems level change, narrative accuracy, and collaborative ways to upend systemic violence.

By the start of 2021, the social and political pushback of the counternarrative, amplifying the voice and lived experience of people of color, and the fight to advance racial justice set in motion a white counterattack. Most recently, critical race theory (CRT) as a theoretical and legal framework, has been distorted and inaccurately misrepresented as anti-white leftist propaganda that argues for differential treatment based on race or ethnicity (Butcher & Gonzalez, 2021). In response, Republican legislatures have essentially deemed critical conversations that explicitly challenge the dominant narrative about racial hierarchy and American exceptionalism as another form of “political correctness” that is “a threat to national unity” (Kilgore, 2021). As of the writing of this introduction, 26 states have introduced or passed laws, including Idaho, Oklahoma, Texas, Tennessee, Iowa, and New Hampshire, to limit teaching CRT or restrict language for educators to discuss race and gender (Schwartz et al., 2021). Consequently, CRT has become the scapegoat of political correctness, whereby any critiques or criticism of how race and racism have manifested throughout history, across public institutions, through policy decisions, resource allocations, and administrative actions is deemed as un-American.

Critical race theory (CRT) allows scholars to examine issues (e.g., legal, educational, institutional, societal) with a clear understanding of the ways in which the system of racism acts as a form of oppression for Black, Latino, and Indigenous People in the United States. Specifically, CRT argues that racism is systemic and embedded in U.S. institutions, thereby able to sustain itself without individual racists. CRT is rooted in primary basic assumptions that argue: (1) racism is ordinary, not an aberration, but ingrained within the ordinary practices of society; (2) interest convergence is at play in U.S. systems. Interest convergence argues that white powerholders will only work to advance racial justice if there is convergence between their own interests and justice advances; and (3) context matters and thus, the lived experience is a tool for highlighting the counternarrative (Delgado & Stefancic, 2000; Zuberi, 2011).

Understanding the historical context of U.S. society and accepting the role race has played in informing institutions, attitudes, behaviors, and actions is fundamental to addressing persistent racial inequities and intergenerational disparities. The race-consciousness that CRT advances is a necessary element in fostering and understanding the contested position of those in power with racialized minorities in a position of subjugation (Zuberi, 2011). By integrating social and cultural factors, outside of White, male, heterosexual affluence, into the research lens, CRT represents a challenge across “disciplinary silos to fashion a more integrated and common-sense account of how race shapes social life” (p. 1590).

This special symposium examines CRT across public and nonprofit spaces to better understand the effects of denying race and racism within the spaces they govern.

Crawford uses interest convergence to examine ongoing racial inequities associated with the growing number of laws legalizing marijuana across the United States. In this piece, Crawford highlights how marijuana laws are void of the restorative justice initiatives necessary to address the costs Black people have paid as a consequence of their overcriminalization due to the “War on Drugs.” He further explains how these laws continue to reproduce inequity by maintaining the interests of whites as the expense of those who continue to bear

the brunt of marijuana related “crime” and offers insights on ways legal remedies can limit the collateral consequences of those impacted by the criminalization of cannabis.

Conyers and Wright Fields explore institutional racial paralysis (IRP) within organizational cultures. The authors reveal how colorblindness supports status quo efforts to remain idle on advancing racial issues. CRT is used to examine the manifestations of institutional racism through the four-stages of IRP: idleness, concealment, evolving modus operandi, and pervasive. As institutions continue to remain silent on issues of race, the consequences are catastrophic of people with marginalized identities both internal and external to the organization.

Gourrier uses CRT to explore the root causes of Baltimore’s racial, social, and economic divide, which has produced “Banking Deserts.” In this regard, Black people have inadequate access to legitimate financial institutions and are therefore subject to predatory practices by lenders. Black neighborhoods, consequently, experience collective disinvestment, concentrated poverty, and increased crime. This cycle becomes socially constructed as the normative reality for Black people and their respective communities.

Nickels and Leach examine the utility of incorporating feminist and intersectional theories into nonprofit research. These theories appreciate the unique experiences of people of color, in a sector that is rooted in hegemony of white privilege, in ways that offer an alternative approach to research and engagement based on the lived experience of people directly affected by inequity.

Although ever present across public administration and nonprofit institutions, explicit discussions and/or initiatives designed to address racism, at the root level, are rare. While an increasingly growing area of interest, the study of public administration continues to avoid explicit conversations capable of leading to institutional shifts in racial justice. The articles included within this symposium move the study of racism (as a system of oppression) by using critical race theory (as a tool to eradicate this unjust system) within the field forward. Each manuscript offers critical race theory as a tool for public administration to move beyond its traditional notions of neutrality, objectivity, and technical rationality into a discipline and practice that accurately contextualizes history, centers the lived experience, and values racial justice as worthy of prioritization and action.

DISCLOSURE STATEMENT

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